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METRO

UPCOMING REDHILLS
METRO

UPCOMING MADHAVARAM
METRO

MADHAVARAM
BUS TERMINUS

RB GOTHI
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PROPOSED METRO LINE

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ROLE CALL

Karisma Kapoor follows up her 2024 comeback with a gritty new role in Abhinay Deo's *Brown* **P6**

metroPLUS THE  **HINDU**

Aesthetic procedures may look simple on social media, but they are still medical procedures and should be approached with the same caution as any other medical treatment. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



for a vampire facial in a spa ended up contracting HIV. She adds, "Any blood-drawing procedure requires proper protocol, inspection, and record-keeping."

This is true of any procedure that involves injections or energy tools, says Dr Anmol Chugh, Associate Director and Head, Plastic and Aesthetic Surgery, CK Birla Hospital, Gurgaon. "Only trained doctors or licensed dermatologists ought to handle these," says Dr Anmol, who also believes that procedures like chemical peels with strong formulas, microneedling and laser work should also be performed in clinical settings. "Mistakes during these processes might lead to scars, uneven colour, burns, or worse, an infection creeping in unnoticed," he says.

Doctors universally agree on this: the only processes that can be safely performed in a non-clinic environment are regular grooming and maintenance. Think waxing, haircuts, pedicures, manicures, or oil massages.

Even something as commonplace as laser hair removal should not be performed without being overseen by a certified doctor, something that Zeishah Amlani, a Bengaluru-based media professional, discovered the hard way, when she went to a wellness centre, offering very low rates, that she had discovered on social media. “They were giving me a full-body laser package for ₹50,000 (six sessions), which should have been a red flag,” says

Zeishah, who ended up getting badly burnt during the treatment.

Lasers are highly technique-sensitive and can cause severe damage if performed incorrectly, explains Dr Bindu Shalekar, founder and medical director of Skin Smart Solutions with centres in both Mumbai and Goa. "Different skin types react differently to laser energy, especially Indian skin, which is more prone to pigmentation and burns," she says.

In her opinion, while technicians can support aesthetic treatments, medical judgment cannot be replaced. "A technician may know how to operate the machine, but they may not always have the medical training to identify complications early or make judgment calls during the procedure."

While the CDSCO clarification is a welcome move, one thing is obvious: caveat emptor is essential when it comes to these procedures. “Check who does the treatment: a certified plastic surgeon or dermatologist must lead it at an official clinic. Find out their background, how long they have been doing such work, and what tools or fillers will go into your skin,” says Dr Anmol, adding that it is best to ignore anything with exaggerated claims, social media stars, or prices that seem too good to be true. “Appearance changes need trained hands, not just willing ones.”

but do short courses and begin doing skin procedures like PRP and microneedling.”

The risks posed by flouting these basic protocols are multifaceted. For instance, given that many of these procedures involve blood, “if you are not careful, multiple diseases can be transmitted, including HIV and hepatitis,” she says, recalling an incident in New Mexico in 2024, when several women who opted

Botox at the spa

The CDSCO's recent clarification that injectables do not qualify as cosmetics comes amid growing concerns among dermatologists who warn against invasive procedures at salons

Preeti Zachariah
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Dr Geetika Srivastava still remembers the patient who walked into her clinic with a granulomatous reaction – a formation of clusters of immune cells – after an injectable treatment performed in a salon. “Adequate aseptic precautions were not followed,” says the Delhi-based dermatologist and founder of Influenz Skin & Hair Clinic, Hauz Khas. “A simple lunchtime procedure ended up leaving the patient with persistent bumps for months,” she says.

This is not an isolated incident. In her decade-long aesthetic practice, Dr Geetika has treated innumerable patients who have faced complications after procedures performed without medical supervision. “I have seen infections, abscesses, asymmetry after injectables, drooping of eyelids after Botox, burns after laser procedures, and early vascular compromise after fillers,” she says, pointing out that aesthetic procedures may look simple on social media, but they are still medical procedures and should be approached with the same caution as any other medical treatment.

This is why she welcomes the recent public notice issued by the New Delhi-based Central Drugs

Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) clarifying that cosmetics are defined as “any article intended to be rubbed, poured, sprinkled or sprayed on” while also specifying what does not fall within that definition: “Products supplied in the form of injectable preparation do not fall under the definition of cosmetics.”

According to her, this is a much-needed directive, given that the beauty and aesthetics industry is expanding rapidly with people far more exposed to aesthetic trends and cosmetic interventions than ever before. “As a result, many people undergo procedures without fully understanding the risks involved or the qualifications required to perform such procedures safely.”

Aanchal Tripathi, founder of Papillon Public Relations, based in Mumbai, is one of them. In April last year, as part of her pre-wedding beauty treatment package, she opted for customised IV drips at a wellness clinic, with centres in

Any blood-drawing procedure requires proper protocol, inspection and record-keeping

DR SHWETHA RAHUL

both Bandra and Churchgate. “I didn’t have the time to do four or five IV drips because I went to them literally 15 days before my wedding,” she recalls. So, they offered to give her a combination of drips that promised glowing skin, weight-loss and maintaining electrolytes balance, says Aanchal.

In June, nearly a month after her last procedure, she started feeling weak and feverish. Further testing revealed that not only had she not needed any of the drips, but the clinic had not left sufficient time between them, which severely affected her electrolyte balance and gut. "I was constantly dehydrated, and even in the ICU twice. It took me six months to recover," she says.

Incidents like these are on the rise, driven by the proliferation of wellness clinics, beauty studios and salons sprouting across the country, offering myriad services that should not be performed without a dermatologist or plastic surgeon, much to the dismay of healthcare professionals like Chennai-based dermatologist Dr Shwetha Rahul.

These include PRP and GFC (regenerative treatments that use a patient's own blood), exosome therapy (which utilises nano-sized vesicles derived from stem cells), mesotherapy (which involves microinjecting substances like vitamins, enzymes, and hormones into the mesoderm or middle layer of the skin) and IV drips filled with antioxidants and vitamins. "There is no protocol in place in these clinics," she says, adding they often do not have certified medical professionals to advise or administer these treatments. "Since hiring a dermatologist is expensive, they instead hire dentists or just an MBBS doctor," says Dr Shwetha. And yes, even Ayush practitioners are getting into the aesthetic clinic space, she says. "They are untrained in the field of dermatology."





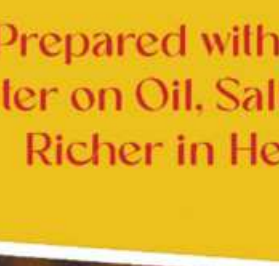
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pick of the week



An artsy weekend

The Monthly Muse returns with a Leonardo da Vinci edition by The Chaos Club, inviting participants to step into the world of the Renaissance genius. Led by artist and educator Halima Safrin, the session explores da Vinci's notebooks, inventions and artworks before participants create their own futuristic ideas using mixed media on vintage paper. On June 6, from 5pm to 6.30pm at Backyard, Adyar. Priced ₹1,499. To register DM@thebackyardclan



Handle with humor

Who is performing? That is part of the joke. At Reddit-humor: The Chennai Late Night Comedy Show, the lineup stays anonymous until the comics step on stage, borrowing a

page from Reddit's culture of hidden identities. The show will bring an evening of unfiltered stand-up, with no topic considered off-limits. At Trinity Studio, Kodambakkam, on June 7 from 8pm onwards. Tickets for ₹200 onwards, available on bookmyshow.com



Retail therapy

Hand embroidery, handcrafted silver jewellery, and contemporary digital art come together at Summer Love, a two-day pop-up at Studio Samasta. Discover Lesley Scen's

hand-embroidered linen pieces under Sewmuchlovee, everyday silver jewellery from Mel's, and Shrikar Madiraju's Confluence series — digital artworks inspired by the spiritual energy of Varanasi and the Kumbh. Till June 6 from 12pm to 8pm at Samasta in Alwarpet.



Sing it loud

Some songs never leave you. Join singer Maaya for an easygoing evening of music, stories, and collective nostalgia, where the audience is encouraged to sing along. Expect familiar

favourites, a few laughs, and plenty of moments that might transport you back to another time and place. Produced by Kika Productions in collaboration with The Backyard Clan, Adyar on June 14, 5 pm onwards. Tickets on allevents.in



Aseem Kapoor (centre) after the show in London; and (below) models showcase his designs. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

of the things that I saw... this can work right now also." Later, he puts it even more bluntly. "People are so much into the now fashion that they forget that the same thing after five years will start looking old and not so relevant."

Looking at the collection, what becomes immediately apparent is that he has not tried to overwrite Satya Paul's visual language. The birds are still there, so are the dots, stripes and zebra motifs. What has changed is the way they move.

The black-and-white striped sari dress is perhaps the clearest example. The print feels deeply rooted in Satya Paul's archive, but the silhouette belongs entirely to Aseem. Rather than lying flat against the body, the fabric twists and gathers into something sculptural.

Historically, Satya Paul built an empire on printed textiles. Here, Aseem takes that heritage and gently pushes it forward. Scarves become necklines, dresses, waist treatments and sculptural elements. It feels contemporary without trying too hard to be contemporary, which is rarer than fashion would like to admit.

The menswear follows a similar logic. Aseem introduces printed tailoring, statement outerwear and coordinated separates that carry the same sense of individuality found in the womenswear.

Because what Aseem seems determined to preserve is not a specific print, product or silhouette, but a way of thinking.

"What remains sacred is always the techniques, the quality, the approach and the aesthetic," he says. Somewhere in that exchange lies a future for Satya Paul that feels neither nostalgic nor entirely new, which may be exactly the point.

Shape of things to come

Aseem Kapoor unveils Untamed, drawing on Satya Paul's four-decade archive while introducing a more contemporary design language

became part of the house's visual vocabulary.

"When I was looking through the archives and I saw prints that were 30 years old and 25 years old, it still had a very modern approach," he says. He found himself returning to the same conclusion over and over again. "Most



Barry Rodgers

barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

When I speak to Aseem Kapoor, the day before his debut showcase for Satya Paul in London, he sounds remarkably composed for a man carrying the weight of a 40-year-old fashion legacy on his shoulders. Well, almost.

"It's a very, very exciting time," he says. "And at the same time, with the kind of attention, the kind of effort we have all put in, being nervous is very likely to happen. And it's a good thing."

The nerves are understandable. Untamed, presented at Lancaster House as part of SXSW London following an invitation from the UK Department for Business and Trade, marks Satya Paul's first international presentation under Aseem's creative direction. It also introduces Satya Paul Menswear to a global audience and signals the beginning of a new chapter for one of India's most recognisable fashion houses.

"I don't want to make Satya Paul into Aseem Kapoor," he tells me. "My whole existence should be what I can add as a layer to an existing legacy brand and what I can elevate in terms of what

already exists."

A graduate of NIFT Mumbai, where his graduating menswear collection Wandering Tribes Gather No Dust won Best Menswear in 2003, Aseem spent nearly 15 years at Tarun Tahiliani before launching his own label in 2020.

Founded in 1985, Satya Paul occupies a unique place in Indian fashion. For decades, women bought the brand as much for the

print as for the garment itself. Long before Indian fashion became obsessed with storytelling, Satya Paul, who was among the first to reimagine the Indian sari as a contemporary fashion statement, becoming known for his conceptual patterns and unconventional use of colour, was also telling stories through bird motifs, dots, stripes, graphic motifs and artist collaborations

Good Earth founder and creative director Anita Lal launches Iti, an 18-product

skincare line developed over six years and drawing on Himalayan botanicals, biomimetic formulations and traditional knowledge

S Poorvaja

poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

Anita Lal keeps circling back to the serenity of the mountains, all the calm and in her case, inspiration, it has to offer.

The founder and creative director of luxury design house Good Earth, Anita recalls how she escaped to her home in the hills for a brief while nearly thirty years ago, after experiencing a severe skin reaction. "I used some skincare that I chanced upon, which compromised my skin barrier. Nothing seemed to suit my burning skin until I found pure rose water, and local mountain oils; wild peach, apricot and rosehip," she says.

This personal experience, and chancing upon Pratima Raichur's book *Absolute Beauty* got her thinking. And now, thirty years after Good Earth launched in 1996 comes Iti, the brand's new skincare line.

"My journey with making skincare started as Amritam with Good Earth, where I was dabbling with bath and body products. The rose facial mist is still very popular, as are the bath oils. And my daughter Simran started Paro in 2018 as well, a brand that was rooted in vedas and spiritual thought," she says, of her tryst with skincare.

Passion project

Anita however calls Iti, which means 'as it is' in Sanskrit, her most personal, creative



(Clockwise from right) Iti has ingredients sourced from the Himalayas; founder Anita Lal; and the brand's Leh berry oil. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A mountain remedy

endeavour yet. Launched with 18 products which includes lotions, serum gels, mists, and cleansers, the brand combines Himalayan botanicals and scientific research. "I took nearly six years to study, learn and experiment. I see Iti as a passion project; one that offers what I consider is the safest, finest and most effective skincare for people from their teenage to old age," she says.

Anita is of the firm belief that skin doesn't need too much pushing or prodding. Iti's biometric formulations, which have been developed after rigorous research, draw on

ingredients that mimic molecules naturally present in the skin, she says. "Our idea with Iti is to keep safety on top of everything," she says.

As dermatologists continue to advocate the use of science-backed skincare, Anita too alludes to recent remarks she had made about how she does not use SPF and the concerns it raised. While she speaks of balancing ayurveda, science and vedic wellbeing, the founder emphasises on not wanting to preach just one way to go about skincare, apart from the need to keep things simple. She is in fact,



in the thick of developing a safe, mineral-based SPF she says.

"Everybody has their own needs so I am not going to say what is good or bad. I highly respect all scientific research that has happened, and for us, it was a question of a long-term and quieter approach that balances the best of all worlds," she says.

Beauty potions

Anita speaks about working with traditional knowledge, natural ingredients and science as going hand-in-hand. "To make one serum or cream for Iti, we must have made at least a hundred iterations or more. The products then had to go through stability tests and many more steps. Research here is the key; I wanted to learn, I worked with Margaret Pawlaczyk-Karlinski, a chemist and aromatherapist, and wanted to be sure of what exactly went into these products," she explains.

Everything is made in their "large, lovely atelier" in Ballabgarh, Anita says, with ingredients sourced from the

Himalayas. "I cannot ever outsource making skincare to factories where they make standard formulations. These days you can put together hyaluronic acid, or retinol and make a serum in three minutes. This is not what I am interested in making," she says.

The first line of products Iti has rolled out includes the Amalaki micellar cleansing oil, Kamala toning lotion, Padma biome drench for hydration, a centifolia rose serum gel and a leh berry rescue oil to soothe the skin, an all-in-one wild peach butter, a rosehip night elixir and a kewra (fragrant screwpine) clay to bring balance to oily skin. Every ingredient used, ranging from Leh berry and lavender to spilanthes acmella (spotflowers, famed for containing a natural, bio-botox), is COSMOS (Cosmetic Organic Standard which is an independent standard for natural and organic cosmetics) certified.

There seems to have been an almost conscious decision to not go fragrance-free. Instead they use rose, pure jasmine patchouli and geranium oils, she says. "When you apply something, it feels like you are doing a ritual for yourself. It must uplift your inner self. Unless you have a medical or a skin issue which requires you to go fragrance free, why deny yourself the joy that comes with this?"

Iti is currently available online, as well as at Good Earth stores in Delhi and Mumbai. Prices upwards of ₹5,500.



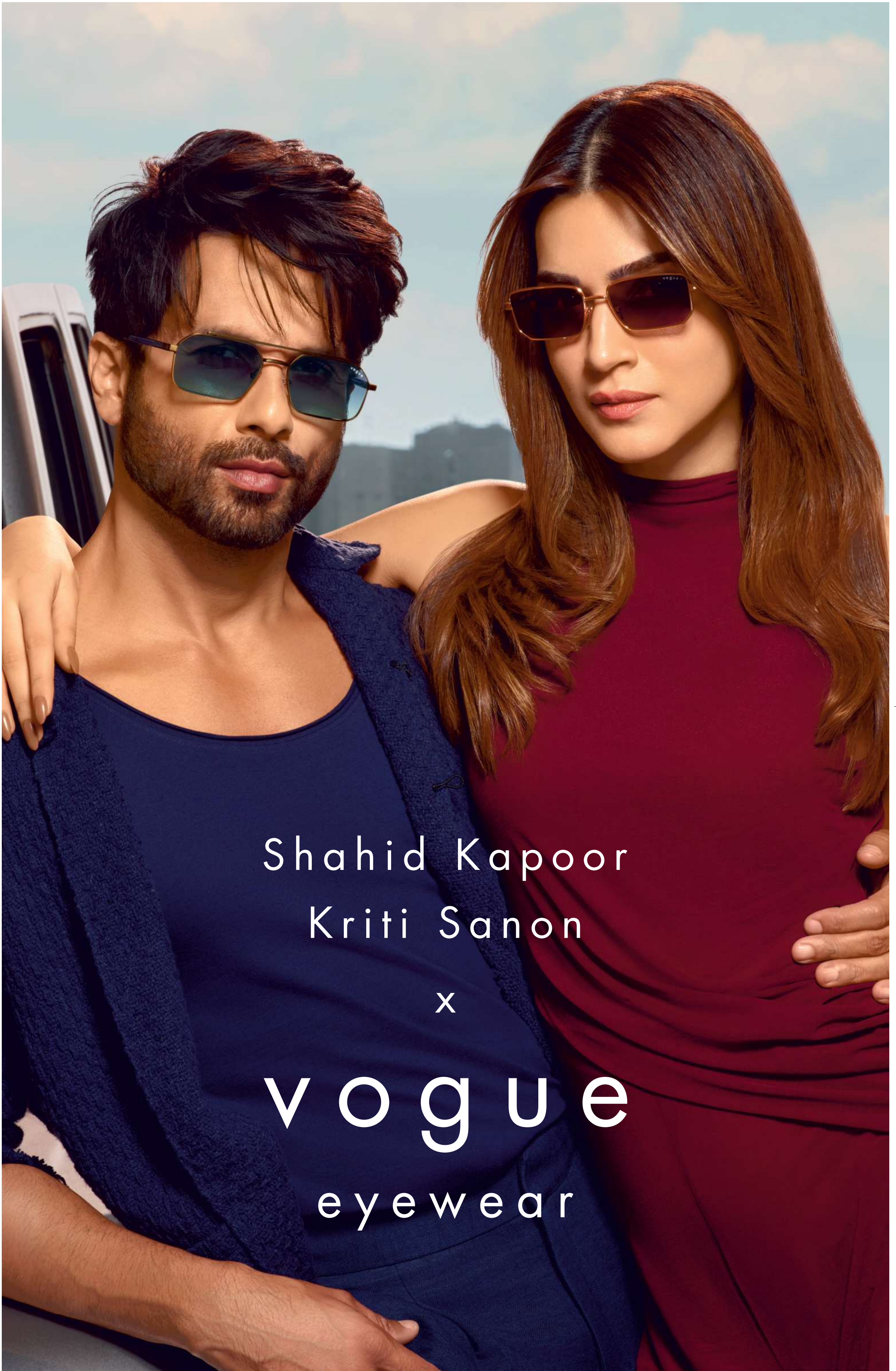
The taste of Meghalaya

The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged and Zhouyu bring the flavours and stories of Northeast India to Chennai on June 6 and 7, by Chef Ahmedaki Laloo from Shillong. The two-day pop-up showcases the cuisines of Meghalaya through a curated menu featuring dishes such as charred foraged mushrooms with smoked black sesame jus, grilled bamboo shoot-marinated chicken, and seasonal greens tempura with roselle dust. The experience also weaves together food, storytelling and conversations inspired by the region's rich cultural traditions. Priced at ₹3,150 per person, all inclusive. For reservations, call 9363036446.



Summer of making

If you are looking for a creative escape this June and July, Apparao Galleries' Craftpreneur Series offers a range of hands-on workshops that blend art, craft and curiosity. Participants can explore still-life photography, palm-leaf weaving, stained-glass making, handmade paper, candle crafting, gold leaf art and natural dyes through guided sessions led by artists and designers. The programme encourages experimentation, skill-building and creative confidence while introducing contemporary crafts as both a hobby and a potential avenue for enterprise. The series brings opportunities to make, learn and create. Till July 27 at Apparao Galleries, Wallace Gdn Third Street. Priced ₹1,000 onwards. To register call 9841022477





(Clockwise from right) The tablescap at Kesar Bagh; Kakori kebab; and the outdoor seating area of Kesar Bagh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Priyadarshini Paitandy

Some dishes require reverence. And that is what the Kakori kebab and sheermal get at Kesar Bagh. As I cut pieces of the delicate lamb kebab and pop them into my mouth, time stands still, the music fades and all I feel is the kind of joy that only an impeccable dish can bring out. Then, I tear into the saffron-rich, mildly sweet sheermal and it is time to write a paean to this classic combination. While the size of the Kakori is intimidatingly long, it is effortlessly polished off in under three minutes.

Kesar Bagh is the new poster kid in Goa's bustling F&B scene. Started by Chef Azaan Qureshi, it serves Awadhi cuisine. Azaan comes from the lineage of Padma Shri awardee Chef Imtiaz Qureshi who is known to have started Bukhara in 1978 and Dum Pukht in 1988 at ITC Maurya, Delhi, the latter along with Chef Ghulam Qureshi (Azaan's father). Azaan learnt the finer nuances of this cuisine from his grandfather and father and was also associated with ITC hotels for 15 years, before starting his first flagship property in Goa in April this year.

His new outpost draws inspiration from Lucknow's Qaiser Bagh, a palace complex built by Wajid Ali Shah, the last Nawab of Awadh. "In

A tale of saffron and fire

Kesar Bagh by Chef Azaan Qureshi brings together classic Awadhi kebabs, gravies, and biryanis in a 180-year-old Portuguese bungalow in Goa

Awadhi cuisine, it's not just the masalas but the dum technique that is special. It makes even less spices seem more complex in the longer process," explains Azaan, adding, "The kebabs melt in your mouth. The Kakori has been perfected over 30-50 years using a technique called galawat, where we use raw papaya that has an enzyme which tenderises meat."

Gurugram was the original

location for this property. But when Azaan and his business partner Priyank Sukhija, CEO and managing director of First Fiddle F&B, stumbled upon what they call "the perfect property" in Goa, they had a change of heart. Kesar Bagh is housed in a renovated 180-year-old Portuguese bungalow that can seat 120 guests across its indoor and two large al fresco dining areas. A courtyard with a marble fountain

strewn with rose petals welcomes you, followed by Kesar, the outdoor bar. The bartender whips up a summer quencher in the form of Mango Kesar Spritzer, a refreshing drink that heralds the start of mango season across the country.

The restaurant, spread across half an acre, follows a light salmon pink and teal colour scheme. Certain elements like the doors from the last century are still intact. Each room opens into another, with different seating layouts and decor. For example, the room where we dine has walls vibrant with paintings by Thota Vaikuntam and olden day accessories mounted onto frames. One of the other rooms has walls lined with mirrors. And from the

high tiled roof hang chandeliers. The only aspect sticking out like a sore thumb is the bulky grey speakers that take away from the vibe the place is going for. But that is not really my concern. I am only focussed on what is on my table – takka paisa kebab that has mashed potato wedged between roundels of cottage cheese. Sounds deceptively simple but needs to be done with precision so all the three components stay together as one while being pan-grilled. Interestingly, takka paisa is the name of a technique used to make kebabs.

The harra kebab Awadhi made with spinach and Bengal gram has a surprise hiding inside. When you cut into it, it reveals a surprise centre of

roasted cashews and khoya. Something I never expected when I saw the staid green kebab on my plate. Next up, creamy, melt-in-the-mouth murgh chandi tikka. Wrapped in edible silver foil, it looks like it escaped the Met Gala afterparty. The other starters like mahi gomti (escallops of red snapper) and labgeer kebab (beetroot and lentils) put up a good fight but fail to secure a podium finish like the rest.

I wash it all down with my Picante, starring curry leaves, and a hint of spice that is balanced by the mild sweetness of fragrant elderflower. For main course, it is gucchi-subz-e-zar and dal ma qureshi with hazari naan and doodh garlic naan (yes, you read that right!) that is kneaded with curd, milk and cheese. The jumbo-sized gucchi is succulent and filled with a bit of clotted cream and potato and cooked with spring onion and pepper in a salan-like gravy. "This dish celebrates morels. My grandfather incorporated gucchi into his Indian cooking after being inspired by French restaurants," he says. The dal is easily outperformed by the morel gravy, which is a rare verdict from me, given I am such a black dal fan. The hazari naan meanwhile is a delight. It peels off in crisp layers and has the flavour of ajwain. You do not even need an accompaniment with it.

How can one go for an Awadhi meal and not try dum biryani? I get a whiff of it even before it is served. The biryani is light and redolent with rose water and saffron, punctuated with perfectly cooked pieces of baby goat. This one is truly a dish fit for royalty. A short walk later – to loosen my belt – I am back for a sweet ending. Shahed-e-jam, a large gulab jamun (as big as my palm) stuffed with honey, pistachio and saffron awaits. While this has nothing to write home about, the kulfī falooda – smooth, with a creamy texture and just the right amount of sweetness – is as perfect as its name: lab-e-mashooq.

For Azaan, this restaurant is an opportunity to not just give diners a taste of authentic Awadhi cuisine but also take them through the different techniques, history, and terms like kebabchi. Awadhi food has reached Tokyo and New York but Azaan wants to further its reach in the country. "If I don't do, who will?" he smiles.

Kesar Bagh is located at 5, Saunto Waddo, Anjuna Mapusa Road, Assagao, Goa. Meal for two: ₹4,000



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In West Bengal's Murshidabad, rare mango varieties are spoken about with the same reverence and specificity that aristocratic families reserve for their ancestors. Most of these mangoes like kohitur, champa, Bimli, rani pasand and anaras, which once flourished across Bengal, have been struggling to survive under the pressures of commercial farming and shrinking orchards. Now, with their saplings and seeds passed between growers, or via donations by orchard owners to city hotels and public gardens, a small network of horticulturists and restaurateurs is reviving these rare varieties across Malda and Murshidabad. One rare variety, and perhaps the most delicate in the world, kohitur, is so soft that it is wrapped in cotton because even

Pulp fiction

Rare mangoes, once grown in Bengal's royal orchards, are being revived and enjoyed thanks to a network of horticulturists and restaurateurs

fingertips can bruise it. The champa carries the scent of frangipani flowers, while the reddish-yellow Bimli is said to have been named after a gardener whose hard work impressed Mir Jafar (1691-1765), erstwhile commander of the Bengal army under Siraj ud-Daulah.

Harvested from history Pradip Chopra, president of the Murshidabad Heritage Development Society, founded in 2010 with the aim of reviving heritage establishments in Murshidabad, and organiser of the

Murshidabad Mango Festival, says the region's mango culture is deeply tied to the Sheherwali community. "Sheherwalis would pour milk into the roots of mango trees or store fruits in rose water," says Pradip.

He notes that many rare mangoes at the Murshidabad Mango Festival are sourced primarily from two orchards: one spanning 60 acres within the Kathgola Palace owned by Sanjay Dugar, descendant of the erstwhile royal family of Kathgola and trustee of Kathgola estate, and another 0.62-acre orchard on the outskirts

(Clockwise from left) Handpicked mangoes being collected; mangoes on display at the Murshidabad Mango festival. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



of Murshidabad owned by Rocky Sk. The seeds and saplings are planted during May, June, July and August. Most of the rare mangoes begin fruiting in the first week of June and disappear by the end of the month.

Rare obsession

Sanjay has spent the last 22 years reviving exotic mango varieties in his Kathgola orchards. "Murshidabad was home to nearly 200 mango varieties like kalapahar, Mohanbhog, molamjam and bira," he says. Sanjay says that kalapahar's identification is its blackish-green skin that darkens further on ripening. Mohanbhog is softer, dessert-like in texture, while molamjam has intense flavour and short shelf-life. Bira is known for its delicate aroma.

He traces part of this history to emperor Akbar, who reportedly maintained an orchard of one lakh mango trees in Darbhanga, Bihar, where experiments were

conducted by crossbreeding mango saplings with fruits and flowers to create distinct fragrances and flavour profiles.

Darbhanga in Bihar was the emperor's seat of experimentation. The saplings were later circulated between nawabs and zamindars of Murshidabad.

"A mango called anaras had pineapple-like notes, champa smelled of frangipani and chandankosa smelled like sandalwood," says Sanjay. Preserving these mangoes requires extraordinary patience. Trees can take seven to eight years to bear fruit. Older trees see a reduction in fruition after 40-to-50 years and may slowly die thereafter. Saplings must constantly be grafted from surviving stock.

Sanjay says rare varieties including kohitur, champa, Bimli and rani pasand were planted years ago at Victoria Memorial and ITC Sonar.

Yet, rarity itself makes revival difficult. Kohitur remains scarce even within Murshidabad. The fruit is exported to West Asia, where it is reportedly sold for ₹3,000 to ₹5,000 a piece. In Murshidabad, its prices range between ₹250 and ₹500 per piece.

Preserving heritage

The philosophy of preservation is now finding its way into restaurants like Amar Khamar, located in the heart of South Kolkata, the ingredient-led

lunchroom is attempting to reintroduce Bengal's forgotten mango varieties to urban diners. The restaurant works with farmer networks across Bengal to revive lost rice as well as mango varieties. Last year, it sourced single-estate mangoes like bira, molamjam and champa from Murshidabad.

This year the team has tied up with orchard owners across Malda, Murshidabad, Birbhum and North 24-Parganas to bring rare varieties like rani, baromasi, sindura and more to the restaurant.

Their preservation efforts have also encouraged varieties like himsagar, amrapali and gopalbhog from Malda. Himsagar, a commercial variety is known for its intensely sweet fibreless flesh, amrapali for its deep orange pulp and concentrated flavour, and gopalbhog for its early-season ripening and rich floral sweetness, have been transformed into amsattos, Bengal's traditional sun-dried mango leather available throughout the year at Amar Khamar. The pulp is dried naturally, without adding sugar, allowing the distinct flavour of each mango to come through.

Awareness, growers say, still largely comes from orchard-owning families, collectors and mango enthusiasts. This month, the Murshidabad Heritage Development Society will once again organise its annual month-long mango festival in Azimganj. Before June, many varieties are unavailable. By July, several disappear again. Their fragility defines them. Many are too soft, too seasonal and too temperamental for commercial supply chains.

In Murshidabad's orchards, revival is about preserving an entire vocabulary of taste that Bengal once knew intimately and is now learning to remember again.



(Below) Zetu's AC-ventilated outdoor seating area; (right) a 500-year-old banyan tree overlooks the main courtyard; and (far right) rum-based Amba Clarified, with mango, carrot and pineapple. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



conversation between modern Delhi and Sri Lanka, not just through the food, but through the design as well," she says. When it comes to the food, there is a genuine sense of storytelling on the plate, culled from Sri Lankan home kitchens and street corners. Chef Dush Ratnayake from Sri Lanka leads the way, with Indian chefs Mohit Kumar and Romil Malhotra. We begin our meal with choon paan butter flight – baked bread served with a trio of colourful flavoured butters. The fiery orange tandoori butter pays homage to India, white nori and citrus represent the sea, and a green curry leaf pesto is rooted firmly in Sri Lanka. Pillow fight, which reminds us of a seesaw in its presentation, is actually salmon and avocado on puffed rice, an ode to the pillow fights of Sri Lanka's new year celebrations. While the storytelling is on point, the dish lacks the punchy execution of the starters that preceded it. The hardest thing to make on the menu, according to Dush, is the lamprais, though it looks the simplest. Wrapped in a banana leaf, the spiced rice with brinjal and seeni sambol is packed with meatballs and chicken gravy. It is a restrained dish, using just four spices, but there is a rough, alluring complexity to it. The cocktails continue this exploration of Sri Lankan ingredients with frangipani martini and a gin-based kandyan Negroni with rambutan-infused campari and sweet vermouth.



Stepping out of Zetu and walking past the banyan tree again, we feel the bridge between Sri Lanka and Delhi has narrowed a bit and the capital's dining scene is all the richer for it. Zetu is at 1AQ, Seth Sarai, Mehrauli, New Delhi and is open from noon to midnight. A meal for two costs ₹8,000 without alcohol. For reservations call 87960 56111.

Zetu in Delhi introduces diners to contemporary Sri Lankan cuisine in a Geoffrey Bawa-inspired space, via lamprais and a pillow fight

Delhi's island detour

Deepali Dhingra

They say, it is always cooler under a banyan tree. Sitting in the open, indoor-outdoor expanse of Zetu, the new 175-seater at 1AQ in Mehrauli, we find ourselves agreeing with this ancient wisdom. Though, we are not sure if the comfort is due to the majestic, 500-year-old banyan tree anchoring the courtyard or strategically placed outdoor AC vents, we are grateful for it. Surrounded by lush greenery and tropical architecture inspired by legendary Sri Lankan architect Geoffrey Bawa, the restaurant, built around contemporary Sri Lankan cuisine, feels sophisticated yet unpretentious.

Derived from Setu – the Sanskrit word for bridge – the founders Sarah Nikahetiya, Anurag Dania, Abhishek Mathur and Sagar Garg gave the name a “zingy Z” to give it a sharper, modern ring. Sarah, a former diplomat with the British High Commission, stayed in Delhi for a couple of years and fell in love with the capital before moving to Colombo, Sri Lanka. The idea for Zetu took shape during her frequent flights back and forth across the ocean. “When you leave Colombo on your way to Delhi, that little string of islands between the two countries is the last thing you see when you exit Sri Lankan airspace. It’s such a small gap, but a significant one. We wanted to capture that



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Shade that *thrills*

Actors Karisma Kapoor and Jisshu Sengupta inhabit the unsettling world of director Abhinay Deo's *Brown*

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Karisma Kapoor gets a striking makeover in director Abhinay Deo's upcoming ZEE5 show, *Brown*. Playing the troubled investigator, Rita Brown, Karisma takes on a role fraught with complexity as she channels the character's anger and frustration through her bluish-green eyes. Set in Kolkata's gritty bylanes, bureaucratic indoors and chirpy media houses, the show features a visual landscape that is new for Karisma, who sheds her popular image of a romance lead from the 90s. "I had said no to the series, like I normally do to most of the work that comes my way," she reveals. Abhinay gives some insight into why the actor might have said no to the show. "While introducing her character, I told Karisma that Rita Brown is a chain smoker and an alcoholic, who just wakes up and goes to her job like it's a huge burden. I told Karisma that she shouldn't do much make-up and set her hair. Maybe I was a bit too explicit in pitching the show," he

smiles. Karisma adds, "No, I think that was the challenge. Because I don't do things that Rita does. I am not a drinker or a smoker. People see me in a different light, and this was stripped of everything possible. That was the beauty of it," says Karisma. That's what excited her on the set when they were shooting in Kolkata in June. "First, we were trying to deal with the heat, but then Abhinay came to me one day and said, 'Make the sweat your character'. So, there were no touch-ups or anything. I would just crush my shirt further and give my shot," says Karisma. *Brown* is adapted from the book *City of Death* by Abheek Barua, and Karisma read it before the shoot. Her co-star, Jisshu Sengupta, however, felt that



reading the script was enough. The Bengali actor plays a psychiatrist in the show. "I am not saying that reading is bad, and it's not that I don't read at all. If something interests me, I might. I have acted in many biopics, but I have never read those biographies. Reading is secondary for me, but it's the experiences and environment that are important. I learn from people around me," he says. It is the environment that stands out in *Brown*. With a tinge of yellow and blue visuals, the series recreates the eeriness in the tale. "Before we went on floors, I had some words in my mind about the show which I wanted to share with the team. One of them was 'uncomfortable', and I told everyone that the entire series should leave everyone feeling that way. So, the choices of colour, framing, texture, and

(Clockwise from left) Stills from *Brown*, featuring Karisma Kapoor and Jisshu Sengupta; the series marks Karisma's second release after her comeback in 2024. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



props are designed to make audiences feel uneasy. I didn't want it to look normal, as everyone is used to normal," Abhinay says. The show marks Karisma's second release after her comeback in 2024 with *Murder Mubarak*. The actor has taken breaks in her career, the longest of them being after her marriage in 2003. The 2012 romantic thriller *Dangerous Ishhq* marked her comeback after over a decade. Has taking a break from acting changed her perspective? "It does change, but acting is like swimming or riding a bicycle. You never forget that; it's ingrained in you," she says. "When I come back on set now, it has to be exciting enough. Otherwise, I am happy not being on set," she adds. The actor notes how the industry has changed since the 90s. "I have done films where there were no scripts. We would not even know our dialogues when we were on set. I had grown in the industry seeing a time like that, and now everything is so detailed; we have bound scripts, we do rehearsals and meetings," she says. "The sincerity, however, remains the same. Whether it is giving a good shot and the team being in the same space, doing their best. That emotion has not changed in 30 years," she concludes. *Brown* will be available to stream on ZEE5 from June 5



Game plan
Sony and Santa Monica Studio have officially unveiled *God of War Laufey*. Revealed during the June 2026 State of Play presentation, the new game places Faye at the centre of the story for the first time.

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Malayalam

A ‘Marco’ universe entry



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One can sit through something as intolerable as *Kattalan* only if one can invent some distraction. A possible diversion could be to keep a count of the humans and elephants killed during the film’s two-hour duration. But halfway through, you are bound to lose track as the killings are just too many, even in a single sequence, to get an accurate number. In the end, one realises that the biggest casualty of this relentless assault on the senses is neither humans nor elephants, but cinema itself.

The dishonesty of it all is evident in how it treats its characters. To fill the emotional void at the centre of the film, one or two characters, like a physically challenged young girl, are introduced randomly and immediately turned into victims of some violent act, which would then set off some pathos-inducing background score.

It is not surprising, for *Kattalan* belongs to the same universe as *Marco*, perhaps one of the most violent films ever made in Malayalam. Violence, in this universe, is an end in itself. Situations are created to unleash maximum violence, which is piled on until we are desensitised enough to stop caring. The action choreography itself, despite the presence of an acclaimed team, is not aesthetic enough to write home about. It is one jangled mess of dislocated limbs and splattered brains, much of it filmed too fast to make any sense of who is fighting whom. The scenes involving a few machine gun-toting kids and sequences of children watching approvingly as the elders unleash violence make one wonder about the thought process that went into the making of the film.

All that action and violence is built around a very basic story that has already been seen in countless films, although the treatment shows that the makers had ‘pan-India’ ambitions like *Pushpa* and *KGF*. An entire village deep in the forest is under the rule of Maari (Sunil), a feared ivory smuggler, who unleashes wanton violence on the hapless villagers who also work for him. When another gang attempts to scuttle his business and capture the cartel, he enlists the help of Anthony (Anthony Varghese), a man adept at smuggling stuff even through tightly controlled borders.

Debutant director Paul George appears to have been given the task of expanding the *Marco* universe by its production team. Although the names of three writers, including the director, are listed, the film does not seem to have a screenplay long enough to fill a page.

Ravi Basrur splits the eardrums with his brand of loud, unimaginative jingle-jangle that passes for background score these days. The cold commercial calculations behind this project are evident in how popular influencers pop up one after the other just to show their faces and draw cheers from their respective ‘fanbases.’ Most of them don’t even have a line of dialogue. The three post-credit sequences threaten to expand the agonising universe in the coming years.

Kattalan is currently in theatres

Kattalan

Director: Paul George

Cast: Anthony Varghese, Sunil, Jagadish, Dushara Vijayan, Kabir Duhan Singh, Parth Tiwari

Storyline: A feared ivory cartel head recruits an expert smuggler when a rival attempts to scuttle his business and take control of the cartel.



Largely gripping but patchy

A potent premise and a riveting Preity Mukundhan power this martial arts actioner, though its convoluted villain saga and predictable writing blunt the impact

Tamil

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A Karate master father, a homemaker mother, and a pharmacist uncle. The life of IT professional Nila (a fantastic Preity Mukundhan) seems quite simple and benevolent – she goes to her office, plays video games on her mobile, and spends time in her uncle’s medical shop, grudgingly looking at an old television set he refuses to let go. Nila’s life, to an unassuming viewer, may not seem anything too extraordinary. Still, one key piece of information reveals that perhaps this must be the kind of ‘family life’ backdrop that most assuredly camouflages a superhero origin story. Nila isn’t just any other ordinary human, and neither is that Karate master, homemaker, or pharmacist. *Blast*, directed by Subash K Raj, is a martial arts actioner pegged around one very potent *Drishyam*-esque idea – what if a family of martial arts pros is forced to step out of their normal lives to fight against injustice when nefarious men find their door? And director Subash comes off in flying colours by conceptualising a terrific set-up that makes use of this idea.

The beating heart of the story is Preity Mukundhan’s Nila, who avoids becoming a merely gender-swapped routine action hero. There’s real moral and emotional backing to why Preity is the way she is, and Subash allows her the time to make her case. Nila’s quest started when she was a child. As she fumed with rage due to a ragging incident, her father, Rajaram (Arjun), told her, “fight back if you are in the right” and “fight against injustice even if the victims are strangers.”

And the introductory scene to the now-grown-up Nila’s bravado is inherently gripping. A goon is sent flying into a rowdy’s den, and a perplexed henchman walks out to find the “man who hit” his colleague, urging Nila to step aside,

Blast

Director: Subash K Raj

Cast: Preity Mukundhan, Arjun, Abhirami, Vivek Prasanna

Storyline: A fierce woman, along with her martial artist parents, vows to take down a corrupt syndicate

because it can’t be a woman, isn’t it? Nila enters, and so does mayhem. In fact, one of the smartest choices Subash makes is in how he retains this inherent, normalised sexism in how the men see Nila throughout. In a later instance, a villain looks past Rajaram and Nila because they seem like an ordinary father and daughter. Where Subash takes a misstep is in how he treats a sexual harassment arc featuring Nila and her abusive manager; it makes way for a good masala cinema moment, but Subash laces it with humour, and it neither reveals anything new nor does it seem to care to extend the idea that the world Nila lives in is already calibrated to look down on women and feast on their vulnerabilities. Also, you begin to get slightly impatient as the film keeps revelling in the idea that a woman is bringing all the action – when will the conflict arise?

Nila constantly gets into trouble as she refuses to bow down in the face of injustice, to the pride of her father, but to the dismay of her mother, Neelaveni (Abhirami, too, can kick some bottoms). And it doesn’t take much to guess where the setting is headed. We simultaneously begin to follow the making of a Black Opal mining scam that an evil businessman, Varun Dhayalan (John Kokken), is spearheading. The project, which puts the hillside village of Keelakadu in danger, would bring in ₹7000 crores worth of minerals, of which a minister (PL Thenappan) takes ₹1000 crores. This whole arc operates like a rather convoluted spiral of villainy – helping Varun move the money needed to bribe the minister is a dreaded assassin named Abraham (Arjun Chidambaram), and helping Abraham is a gangster named Kirubhakaran (Pawan), and under him works a henchman whose friend is a low-life chain snatcher, Toby (Vinod Sagar), and Toby gets caught in a station where Inspector Arunagiri (Dileepan) is investigating Abraham’s identity, and under Arunagiri works a corrupt cop who wants Kirubha’s help to save his job. I guess you could already see where *Blast* might have derailed.

A lion’s share of screentime is accorded

to explain each step in this often yawn-inducing villain saga, all while you are patiently waiting to see the tip of the whirlpool land on Nila’s doorstep and suck her martial arts family in. When it does, it is as explosive as you expect, at least until the intermission mark. While these unidimensional villains test your patience – only Arjun Chidambaram is written and presented with flair – you are left waiting for the next high moment, especially since Subash seems to have a knack for staging such mass-y scenes. But again, how much can Preity and Arjun do when the writing begins to dip into cliches and conveniences? After a point, *Blast* turns out to be quite tedious in the final act, making you wonder how a leaner, crisper, and more anchored screenplay could have been.

All that aside, however, what truly fascinates one is how, despite *Blast* being helmed by a male director and starring an action star like Arjun, it moves around its female protagonist, Nila, and every major decision is made keeping the two central women as opposing but counterbalancing poles – Neelaveni’s moral anchor prioritising the family’s peaceful life above all, and Nila’s moral anchor pushing them to be knights of justice. In fact, even in one of the most pivotal moments of the film, the choice to decide a villain’s fate is placed rightfully on Nila’s shoulders. It is great to see Arjun take a step back to let Abhirami and Preity shine, while Vivek Prasanna, as Nila’s pharmacist uncle, gets a *Jailer*-esque moment that is sure to become a highlight in his career. Helping all of them are the able technicians, be it the sharp, slick cinematography, innovative and adrenaline-pumping action choreography, and Ravi Basrur’s assured music choices.

That said, *Blast* is a Preity Mukundhan show all along, and the *Star*-actor knows how to pack a punch, alright! In a different film, where more ingenious ideas are spring-loaded for mass elevations, *Blast* would have truly become her career-defining big bang.

Blast is currently running in theatres

Reclaiming childhood wonder

Hindi

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The greatest superpower of cinema is the ability to make us believe again. Jackie Shroff’s little summer adventure, *The Great Grand Superhero: Aliens Ka Aagman* doesn’t just ask us to believe in flying grandfathers or marauding aliens, it invites us to believe in something far more radical in these times of attention and trust deficit. The film tells us that a wrinkled, mischievous Dadaji can still be the mightiest hero in a child’s universe, and that childhood imagination isn’t childish – it’s the original superpower.

Intelligent, imaginative, but lonely, young Dipu (Mihir Godbole is pitch-perfect) fabricates grand stories to win over new friends in new schools and new towns where his father gets transferred. In his script, his grandfather (Jackie Shroff) is a superhero who fights aliens. The tone is secretive, and Dipu limits the age



group to under-18 because he perhaps knows his adventure will not pass the adult scrutiny.

He first sparks the curiosity of the inquisitive Laddoo (Shivansh Chorge is absolutely believable), who mixes the superhero tale with divine intervention. Soon, the entire class is keen to see Dipu’s Dadaji and his prowess. But his grandfather, Jagdish Chandra comes across as a regular pensioner with gastric issues and a mortal fear of lizards. Dipu paints it as a facade to hide his heroics from ordinary mortals, but his friends

want to see what the granddad is capable of.

The twist comes when Dadaji learns about his character in Dipu’s story, and he claims he is indeed a superhero. When real aliens appear, Dipu’s tall tales collide with reality, and we get a rush of nostalgia and adrenaline in equal measure. Like the adults in the story who react with scepticism or exasperation, we get to chuckle at the absurdity while secretly rooting for the fantasy to win.

While the child actors hold the

centrestage, the good old Jackie brings warmth, humour, gravitas, and his passion for a greener world that makes you want to believe Dadaji really has hidden powers. Launched as the *Hero* (1983), once upon a time, writer-director Manish Saini uses the star’s history as a campy, comic-book style superhero in *Shiva Ka Insaaf* (1985) to add a meta-layer, making the believe again theme even stronger.

The film cleverly positions the audience as half-insider, half-outsider to the child’s fantasy world. We’re not fully immersed in the boy’s claims, as his gullible classmates are. Instead, we hover at a slight remove, watching the grand myth-making with adult awareness. This distance is where the satire sparkles.

While upholding the power of storytelling, a diminishing art in a know-all world, the film gently satirises how kids weaponise their imagination for survival – to fit in, mask loneliness, or gain status in a new school. By letting us see the gap between the boy’s epic narration and the mundane reality, it creates delicious ironic humour.

It is hard for a studious boy to make friends. In fact, until Dipu cooks up a story, his classmates wonder if he is an ISI agent. When Dadaji comes up with a soft story about his childhood heroism, Dipu demands something with action and violence, in line with the current trend. While Laddoo is a staunch believer, the doubter-in-chief among

The Great Grand Superhero

Director: Manish Saini

Cast: Jackie Shroff, Mihir Godbole, Shivansh Chorge, Bhagyashree, Prateik Babbar, Sharat Saxena

Synopsis: A restless young boy, constantly shifting towns, spins tall tales about his grandfather being a secret superhero who battles aliens to impress his new classmates.

his classmates is the son of a nosy local news reporter. The environmental agenda of aliens for a clean India resonates, and when their grievances about their lazy representation in Bollywood come to the fore, it becomes a playful commentary that ties childhood curiosity to the larger theme.

However, the imaginative potential of the first half, where reality and fantasy blur delightfully, is replaced by functional explanations and set-piece escalation in the second, as the makers trade mystery for clarity. As they take a classroom approach, the storytelling becomes a little too straightforward, a message-driven engine. The VFX fireworks try to compensate with spectacle, but they often feel generic and not particularly inspired.

Still, in a genre that’s been wheezing under the weather for years, *The Great Grand Superhero* arrives as a genuine breath of fresh air.

The Great Grand Superhero is currently running in theatres

